

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Coaching Plan

A structured plan to help a team member grow a specific capability through goals, practice and honest feedback.

Purpose

Coaching is how you deliberately grow the capability of your team rather than hoping people develop by osmosis. This plan turns a vague intention ("Dan should get better at leading") into a concrete development path: a clear goal, the specific skills behind it, real opportunities to practise, and a feedback loop that keeps it honest. It is a growth-and-development tool — distinct from managing under-performance, which is covered by the Performance Conversation Planner.

Good coaching is mostly asking, not telling. Your role is to create the conditions — stretch opportunities, safety to try and fail, and specific feedback — in which the person does the growing.

When to use it

- Developing a capable team member towards their next role or a broader remit.
- Building a specific skill the team needs — leadership, automation strategy, stakeholder communication.
- Supporting a new or ramping hire to reach full effectiveness.
- As the constructive, forward-looking counterpart to a 1:1, where growth conversations often begin.

SCOPE NOTE — COACHING VS FORMAL PERFORMANCE PROCESS

This is a development tool for helping willing people grow. It is not a mechanism for managing serious under-performance or conduct. Where a situation is one of genuine under-performance, any formal action must follow your organisation's HR policy and local employment law. This template is a planning aid, not legal or HR advice, and never a substitute for proper process.

Instructions

1. Agree the development goal with the person — coaching is done with someone, never to them. It must be a goal they actually want.
2. Break the goal into the specific, observable skills or behaviours that make it up.
3. For each skill, identify a real opportunity to practise inside the actual work — a stretch task, leading a session, owning a decision.
4. Define what "good" looks like so both of you can recognise progress.

5. Set a cadence of feedback and reflection, most naturally inside the existing 1:1.
6. Agree the support you will provide — cover, introductions, air-cover to try and occasionally fail.
7. Review and adjust as they grow; retire skills that are met and add new stretch.

Worked example

A coaching plan co-created with Sofia Alvarez, the senior QA engineer and informal team lead, to grow her from respected exploratory tester into a credible technical-leadership role — building on her strengths and mindful of her wariness after last year's failed change.

Element	Detail
Development goal (hers)	To be ready and confident to take on a formal QA lead / test-lead role within the next few months.
Why it matters	Sofia already leads informally and is trusted by the team; formalising it grows her and gives the team stable leadership. She wants it, but wants it done properly this time.

Skill to build	How she will practise it (real work)	What good looks like
Setting test strategy, not just executing	Co-lead the design of the new shared quality gate with me.	She can articulate and defend a risk-based approach to Priya without me in the room.
Influencing sceptical stakeholders	Lead the conversation with Marcus about payments testing, with me coaching beforehand and debriefing after.	Marcus engages with a QA idea because Sofia framed it in his terms, not because I mandated it.
Delegating and developing others	Mentor the recent QA hire through their ramp-up.	The new hire is productive and points to Sofia as the reason.
Communicating quality upward	Draft the monthly executive quality update; I review before it goes.	Her draft leads with risk and trend, not activity, with minimal edits from me.

Element	Detail
Feedback cadence	A standing 15 minutes in each fortnightly 1:1 for coaching reflection, plus a debrief after each stretch opportunity.
Support I will provide	Air-cover to make calls (and occasionally get them wrong), an introduction to Priya as a leader in her own right, and explicit, public credit for the team's exploratory strength she built.
Addressing the automation scar	Name last year's failed "automate everything" push openly, agree what we will do differently (incremental, team-owned), so she trusts this change is not a repeat.
Review point	Six weeks: assess readiness, adjust the stretch, and decide next steps together.

Why this works: the goal is genuinely Sofia's, the practice happens inside real, visible work rather than a training course, and it explicitly confronts the trust barrier (the previous failed change) that would otherwise quietly sink the effort.

Blank reusable version

Element	Detail
Development goal (theirs)	
Why it matters (to them and the team)	

Skill to build	How they will practise it (real work)	What good looks like

Element	Detail
Feedback cadence	
Support I will provide	
Review point	

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Setting a goal you want for them rather than one they want for themselves — motivation collapses fast. Coaching by telling: doing their thinking instead of drawing it out. Sending someone on a course instead of giving them real work to grow in. Defining fluffy goals ("be more strategic") with no observable "good looks like". Offering no air-cover, so the stretch feels like a trap where any mistake counts against them. Never reviewing, so the plan quietly dies. And the serious one: dressing up a performance or conduct problem as "coaching" to avoid a proper process — that is unfair to the person and outside what this tool is for.

How to interpret / use it well

- Real work beats training courses. People grow fastest with genuine responsibility and a safety net, not slides.
- Ask more than you tell. If you are doing most of the talking, you are mentoring or instructing, not coaching.
- Make "good looks like" observable, so progress is a shared fact rather than your opinion.
- Confront the invisible barriers — a past failure, a confidence gap, a trust issue — or they will silently defeat a technically sound plan.
- Feed it from your 1:1s and hand credible growth stories to the executive level; a QA leader who visibly grows people earns disproportionate trust.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The best coaching opportunities are the pieces of your own job you are afraid to let go of. Handing Sofia the quality-gate design or the executive update feels risky precisely because it matters — which is exactly why it grows her. Delegate the things that stretch, keep only what genuinely needs you, and you build a leader instead of a dependant.